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Culture (OWC): [Nuer \(FJ22\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1931, 1936

Coverage Date: 1930-1936

Place Coverage: Sobat And Jonglei Provinces, Sudan

Section Title(S): III

III

When a ghost comes to trouble the living it is said to *cien* them. It is useful to discuss this concept in the light of another, that of *biit*, to curse,¹ because the two are closely connected, the ability of a ghost to harm being the *post mortem* operation of the projective power of the psyche, the power to harm another through the mind and the heart.

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The curse of certain persons in Nuer society is believed to be effective if they have been wronged. If they utter curses without due cause (*cuong*) the curses will either be ineffective or harm the speakers of them. A man curses another by uttering an invocation (*lam*)—which in this context is an imprecation—over, or about, him; and Nuer distinguish different kinds of curse by reference to the relationship of the persons implicated in it— *biit gwan*, the curse of a father, *biit nara*, the curse of a maternal uncle, *biit kuaara*, the curse of a leopard-skin priest, and so forth. Some of these curses are regarded as weightier than others.

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The curse of father or mother is serious. A man may curse his son for constant disobedience and for meanness, especially for refusing him meat. Indeed, any old man may curse a youth for refusing him food, because both in a general sense and in terms of the age-set system all youths are sons to the aged, but his curse would not be as weighty as that of the true father. 'A father's curse is to hunting, to fishing, and to hoeing, but he will not curse him (his son) to cattle.' The youth may then miss his mark in hunting, fishing, and war, and his crops may fail. He may also injure himself in these occupations, or suffer one of the many possible misfortunes that beset a traveller, both in the literal sense of mishaps to one on a journey and in the figurative sense of evils that face a man on his journey through life, which the Nuer, who have a liking for meiosis, speak of collectively as 'thorns'. At its worst the curse of a

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father or mother may be a *biit liagh*, a curse which results in death. However, 'a father will not curse his son to cattle', because the cattle belong to the lineage and if he caused them to die he would only be harming himself and his kinsmen and ancestors.

¹ A *biit* is a curse in the sense of consigning a person to misfortune and not in the sense of swearing at a person, which is *kwith* or, where there is a joking relationship, *leng*.

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